Final Touch

User manual

The rough-mix plug-in: put it on the master at the end of the session. It listens to the track, cleans it, adds colour and raises the level while it stays clean.

Version 1.0 Mac: AU, VST3 Windows: VST3, standalone app



At a glance

Final Touch gets you a clean rough mix you can send out at the end of a recording session. It works on the whole mix, once the tracks are in place. For an official release, proper mastering is still the way to go.

What it does

It measures the track, corrects the tonal balance for the chosen style, holds back the frequencies that spill over, adds colour, impact and air, then raises the level up to a ceiling, while the sound stays clean.

What it doesn’t do

It doesn’t touch individual tracks and won’t fix an unbalanced mix at the source. If the diagnosis flags a problem (clipping, phase), fix it in the mix.

Installation

On Mac

Open the .dmg file and run the installer. It puts the AU and the VST3 in the Mac’s plug-in folders. The plug-in isn’t signed by Apple: on first launch, open System Settings, then Privacy & Security, and click “Open Anyway”.

On Windows

Run the .exe installer. It puts the VST3 in C:\Program Files\Common Files\VST3 and a standalone version in your programs. If Windows shows “Windows protected your PC”, click “More info”, then “Run anyway”.

> Then restart your DAW or have it rescan plug-ins: Final Touch shows up in your effects list.

Quick start

1 Put Final Touch last on the master

Until you click Listen, it passes the sound through untouched. You can leave it on while recording: its latency is about 6 ms.

2 Pick a style

Rap, Trap, RnB, Afro or Pop. The style sets the six knobs, the target tonal curve and the loudness ceiling.

3 Play a full section, then click Listen

The hook is ideal. For about twenty seconds, the plug-in measures the track and sets the tonal balance and the level. The steps show on screen.

4 Compare with Before / After

Before and after play at the same loudness, so you hear the processing, not the gain. Adjust the knobs by ear if needed.

5 Bounce

The setting is saved with your session. Make sure After is on and Monitor is set to Studio before bouncing.

> Has the track changed a lot? Click Listen again to run the analysis again.

The interface



1. **Styles**. Rap, Trap, RnB, Afro, Pop. Switching style resets the knobs to its values.
2. **Monitor**. Listening simulation: phone, earbuds, car… For checking only.
3. **Before / After**. Compare the original and the processed sound at the same loudness.
4. **Listen**. Starts the analysis. Turns into Listen again once engaged, Stop during the analysis.
5. **EQ curve**. The track's spectrum in the background, the style target dotted, the correction in black and one coloured curve per control.
6. **Hear what's removed**. Solos what Clean takes out.
7. **Meters**. Integrated loudness (LUFS), short term, true peak, PLR, and the style ceiling.
8. **Diagnosis and platforms**. Problems found during the analysis, and how much Spotify, Apple Music and YouTube will turn the track down.
9. **The six knobs**. See next page.
10. **Window size**. Drag the bottom-right corner (50 to 150 %). The size is remembered.

The six controls

Each knob starts from a value tuned to the style. Treat them as starting points and adjust by ear.

Clean

`0 to 100`

Watches six bands (170 Hz to 7.5 kHz) and holds back only the frequencies that stick out from the rest of the spectrum. On average it works by less than one decibel per band.

`6-band dynamic EQ, tuned to the track's spectrum`

Turn it up if the diagnosis flags harsh highs or aggressive upper mids. Check with Hear what's removed.

Color

`0 to 100`

Adds the warmth of tape and a transformer: round lows, dense mids.

`15 ips NAB tape, Langevin transformer`

Turn it down on a mix that is already saturated or heavy in the low end.

Punch

`0 to 100`

Glues the elements together like a bus compressor, and brings the attack back to kicks and snares.

`SSL G-series bus compressor, Transient Designer`

Turn it up if the mix lacks impact, down if transients snap too hard.

Vocal

`0 to +4.5 dB`

Brings the centre vocal forward around 3 kHz, following its presence. The sides don't move.

`Mid/side presence that follows the voice`

Turn it up if the diagnosis says the mids sit back.

Air

`0 to 100`

Opens the top end: more shine, without harsher sibilance.

`Pultec EQP-1A, Aphex Aural Exciter`

Turn it up if the diagnosis says the mix lacks air.

Loudness

`-16 to -7 LUFS`

Sets the loudness ceiling. The plug-in climbs up to it, and stops lower if the limiter strains.

`True-peak limiter, automatic safeguard`

Moving this knob restarts the loudness tracking. See the "Loudness" page.

Loudness

Quality first, loudness second. Final Touch doesn't try to be as loud as possible: it aims for a ceiling and stops before the sound degrades.

The ceiling

Each style has a ceiling, adjustable with Loudness. The plug-in only reaches it if the limiter stays relaxed.

The safeguard

During playback, the plug-in watches what the limiter does over several seconds. If it works too hard, the level comes down. A dense mix will land a little below the ceiling, by design.

The locked level

After about 30 seconds of full-on music, the level locks. From then on it can only go down. The bounce then sounds like what you heard, wherever you start playback.

Safety

A true-peak limiter is always on at the output: the master never goes above −0.1 dBTP.

Default ceilings

Style	Ceiling
Rap	−11.0 LUFS
Trap	−10.5 LUFS
RnB	−12.0 LUFS
Afro	−11.0 LUFS
Pop	−11.5 LUFS

The tools around

Before / After

Before plays the original at the same loudness as the processed sound. Switch back to After before bouncing: this setting is saved with the session.

Monitor

Studio, Mono, Phone, Earbuds, Laptop, Speaker, Car. The simulation is also heard in the bounce: set it back to Studio before bouncing. It is never saved.

Hear what's removed

Solos what Clean takes out. If you hear important parts of the vocal or the beat, turn Clean down.

Platforms

Spotify, Apple Music and YouTube bring every track to a reference loudness. The figure shows how much your track will be turned down.

Diagnosis messages

Message	What you can do
All clear: the mix is healthy	Nothing to do.
The input already clips	Lower the mix level before Final Touch, or fix the clipping track.
Phase: the mix loses … dB in mono	A stereo track cancels in mono. Check your widening effects.
The mix comes in hot	The mix is already very loud. Lower the master before the plug-in.
Very low input, compensated	The plug-in compensates, but a higher input level is better.
Mids sit back: turn up Vocal	Turn up Vocal.
Harsh upper mids / sibilant highs	Turn up Clean.
Crowded low mids (200–400 Hz)	Thin out the low mids in the mix (beat, vocal).
Very heavy sub below 70 Hz	Lower the sub or bass in the mix.
Lacks air: turn up Air	Turn up Air.
DC offset at the input (removed)	Nothing to do: the plug-in removes it.
Loudness held where the sound stays clean	The safeguard held the level back. Normal on a dense mix.

Troubleshooting

The plug-in doesn’t show up	Restart the DAW or rescan plug-ins. On Mac, check the permission in Privacy & Security.
The sound doesn’t change	Normal until you click Listen.
The bounce doesn’t match playback	Check After, and Monitor on Studio. After Listen, let the full track play for at least 30 seconds so the level locks.
The level feels low	The safeguard may have held it back to keep the sound clean. Raise Loudness if you accept more limiting.

Specifications

Formats	Mac: AU, VST3. Windows: VST3, standalone app
Latency	about 6 ms
CPU load	about 4 % of one core
Non-linear processing	4× oversampled
Output	true peak limited to −0.1 dBTP